

National Digital Learning Policy for Higher Education

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This policy establishes a comprehensive framework for improving digital infrastructure, promoting blended learning and building institutional digital readiness across universities and colleges. It sets out the vision, principles, implementation expectations and governance arrangements that will guide digital transformation in higher education over the coming three academic years.

1. Background

Digital technologies have transformed how knowledge is created, shared and applied. Students increasingly expect flexible, technology-enabled learning experiences, while employers value graduates who are proficient in digital tools and platforms. At the same time, the pace of adoption has been uneven across institutions, exposing gaps in connectivity, hardware, learning management systems (LMS), faculty capacity and student access.

The National Digital Learning Policy responds to this unevenness. It recognises that a successful digital transition depends on more than procuring hardware: it requires deliberate planning, faculty development, content creation, accessibility safeguards and robust data governance. The policy provides a shared reference point for institutions as they modernise teaching, learning and assessment practices.

2. Purpose

The purpose of this policy is to create a coherent, equitable and sustainable framework for digital learning in higher education. It defines the minimum expectations that every institution must meet, the support that will be made available, and the indicators against which progress will be measured.

3. Objectives

- Improve digital infrastructure, including connectivity, devices and learning platforms, in colleges and universities.
- Promote blended learning models that combine face-to-face and online interaction to improve reach and quality.
- Equip classrooms with digital teaching facilities and promote the effective use of learning management systems.
- Build faculty digital capacity through structured training and certification.

- Ensure accessibility of digital resources for all students, including those with disabilities.
- Embed cybersecurity and data privacy safeguards in all digital learning activities.
- Support student digital access through lending schemes, low-cost devices and connectivity support.
- Assess institutional digital readiness and use the results to prioritise investment and support.

4. Scope

This policy applies to all universities, autonomous colleges and affiliated undergraduate and postgraduate institutions that offer programmes under the Higher Education Department. It covers technology-enabled teaching, learning and assessment across degree, diploma and certificate programmes, and extends to the institutional systems that support them, including LMS platforms, digital libraries, examination systems and administrative records.

5. Guiding Principles

- Equity first: digital transformation must narrow, not widen, gaps in access and outcomes.
- Learning-led, not technology-led: tools are chosen to serve clear pedagogical goals.
- Whole-institution approach: infrastructure, people, content and governance advance together.
- Data protection: student information is collected, used and stored responsibly.
- Sustainability: investments are planned for long-term maintenance and renewal.
- Quality assurance: digital learning is held to the same academic standards as conventional instruction.

6. Implementation Framework

6.1 Digital Infrastructure

Every institution must establish, by the end of the first implementation year, a minimum digital baseline: campus-wide connectivity with adequate bandwidth for synchronous online classes, at least one computer-enabled learning laboratory per department (or per 100 enrolled students, whichever is lower), reliable power backup, and a maintained inventory of working devices available for student use.

6.2 Blended Learning and Digital Classrooms

Institutions must progressively convert at least 25% of core course contact hours in every programme to blended delivery by the third year. Digital classrooms must be equipped for live interaction, screen sharing and recorded lectures. Curricula offered in blended format must be approved by the academic council and the institution's Board of Studies, with clear learning outcomes for online and in-person components.

6.3 Learning Management Systems

Institutions must adopt and maintain an LMS that provides course hosting, assignment submission, assessments, discussion forums and gradebooks. The LMS must be accessible on common mobile devices and conform to accessibility standards. Courses uploaded to the LMS must include a syllabus, learning materials, assessment plan and communication guidelines.

6.4 Faculty Digital Capacity

Institutions must ensure all teaching faculty complete a recognised digital pedagogy training programme within two years, and at least 20 hours of professional development in digital teaching annually thereafter. Training must cover LMS use, digital content design, online assessment, accessibility and responsible use of student data. Faculty digital competency is included in annual performance appraisals.

6.5 Accessibility

All digital content must be created or procured with accessibility in mind, including captions or transcripts for video, adequate contrast, keyboard navigation and alternative formats for key materials. Institutions must appoint an accessibility coordinator and provide assistive software where needed.

6.6 Cybersecurity and Data Privacy

Institutions must adopt a baseline cybersecurity policy covering access control, password standards, data backups and incident reporting. Personal and academic data of students must be used only for institutional purposes and never sold or misused. Institutions must designate a data protection officer and publish a simple privacy notice for students and staff.

6.7 Student Digital Access

Institutions must survey student device and connectivity access annually and operate a device lending library for students without access. Institutions are encouraged to negotiate low-cost connectivity packages with internet service providers and to provide on-campus study spaces with reliable connectivity during extended hours.

6.8 Institutional Digital Readiness

Every institution must conduct an annual digital readiness self-assessment covering the dimensions set out in the annexure to this policy. Results are submitted with the institution's annual report and used to agree targets for the following year.

7. Roles and Responsibilities

Stakeholder	Key Responsibility
Higher Education Department	Sets standards, provides funding support, monitors progress and disseminates good practice.
Universities	Deploy infrastructure, approve blended curricula, support affiliated colleges and report on readiness.
Colleges	Implement digital classroom and LMS initiatives, train faculty and support students.
Faculty	Contribute to digital content, deliver blended courses and engage in professional development.
Students	Participate in digital learning, observe academic integrity and provide feedback.

Stakeholder	Key Responsibility
Learner support and IT units	Operate helpdesks, maintain infrastructure and manage data safely.

8. Monitoring and Evaluation

The Higher Education Department will monitor implementation through an annual Digital Learning in Higher Education survey and through the readiness self-assessments submitted by institutions. Key indicators include faculty training completion, share of courses on the LMS, student device access, completion of accessibility audits and uptake of blended learning. A public summary dashboard will be released each year.

9. Review and Revision

This policy will be reviewed every three years, or earlier if a material technology or regulatory change requires it. Institutions and academic associations may propose amendments through a formal consultation process conducted by the Higher Education Department.

10. Conclusion

Digital learning is a means to a deeper end: better, fairer and more engaging higher education. This policy provides the shared framework, standards and monitoring arrangements through which institutions can pursue that end confidently and accountably. Success will depend on sustained commitment from leadership, faculty, staff, students and partners working together.